

Incident Alert 0025. TLP CLEAR.			Date	Breakout Scale
Title	EU – Russian Sanctioned Entities Accessible to EU Audiences on Instagram, Threads, and WhatsApp		06/08/2024	2

Summary

- As of July 31st 2024, at least 5 Instagram, 3 Threads, and 2 WhatsApp pages, accounts, and groups of Russian media entities and individuals sanctioned by the EU, posing as such, or consistently amplifying their content are accessible to EU audiences.
- The pages have around 74k followers across the platforms.
- [Council Regulation No 269/2014](#) prohibits hosting content from these channels or making them available to EU audiences on video-sharing platforms, as clarified in [Commission guidance](#) updated mid-May 2024.

Incident

On Facebook, some official accounts of sanctioned media and individuals are accessible to EU audiences. In addition, other accounts that have repeatedly or exclusively posted content from sanctioned entities also remain accessible. These accounts include:

- four sanctioned media accounts, despite being verified by Facebook as being controlled by the Russian government,
- two accounts of a show from sanctioned media,
- one amplifier account, exhibiting all the hallmarks of sanctioned media (name, logo, only posting content produced by the entity),
- two accounts belonging to journalists or hosts of shows broadcast on sanctioned media entities, frequently posting content from sanctioned entities,
- one personal account of a personality specifically sanctioned by the EU (see Annex I of Council Regulation No 269/2014), including one posting content from sanctioned media.

It is important to note that the search on Threads and Instagram was not as exhaustive as it was on Facebook. This is due to technical limitations, such as the lack of content discovery and social monitoring platforms available to researchers, and the image-based nature of Instagram. Despite not being accessible via the search function, these WhatsApp channels of sanctioned media can be joined via direct links, which are shared by sanctioned media official accounts on other social media platforms.

Narrative

N/A

Impact

Reach: The identified accounts have around 74k followers (the EU share of which cannot be inferred from public data).

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

Objective: [Facilitate State Propaganda](#) – Spread Russian operational content via Facebook.
[Conceal Network Identity](#) - Accounts hiding their affiliation to the Russian state.

Recommendations

- Action taken: Case reported to Meta (06/08/2024), European Institutions, and EU member states.
- Meta should sweep their platforms to automatically identify content with the logos of the sanctioned media and systematically check the list of sanctioned entities and ensure their accounts are not accessible in the EU.

Report	Topic	Evidence	Authors	Content type	Platforms
Link	Sanctions, Russia	Link	Charles Terroille , Science Feedback Saman Nazari , A4E	Video, image, text.	Facebook